

STAGE SEVEN • HARD SKILLS

FIRSTS

ICEBREAKERS / OPENERS

Short, stage-themed warm-ups tied to what each sub-session actually covers

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Icebreakers / Openers

Stage Seven • Hard Skills

PURPOSE

Stage Seven's companion Session Plan splits this stage's six sections into thirteen sub-sessions, given its size (ninety FIRSTS total). This document follows that same structure — one icebreaker per sub-session, thirteen in total, each built directly from that sub-session's actual content.

Given this stage's technical, tool-heavy focus, several of these openers lean into shared, slightly self-deprecating experience (messy spreadsheets, abandoned apps, tools everyone's intimidated by at first) rather than the more personal, identity-focused openers used in earlier stages. That's intentional — hard skills anxiety responds well to normalizing that everyone starts somewhere.

Each includes the instructions to read to the group, a time estimate, and a short note on why it's specifically the right opener for what comes next.

Thirteen Openers, One Per Sub-Session

SUB-SESSION 1A

Spreadsheet Horror Stories

TIME: 8 min

1. Quick round-robin: "What's the messiest, most chaotic spreadsheet you've ever had to deal with, yours or someone else's?"
2. One sentence each, no elaboration needed — keep it fast and a little funny.
3. Facilitator notes the recurring themes (no structure, unclear ownership, no backup) on a board without naming who said what.

WHY THIS WORKS

Surfaces, painlessly, the exact failure modes K1 and K62 are designed to prevent, before any formal teaching begins.

SUB-SESSION 1B

Guess the Trend

TIME: 8 min

1. Show the group a simple line chart with the labels hidden (just the shape of the trend).
2. Quick guesses: what real-world thing might this represent?
3. Reveal the actual data and discuss: how much did the shape alone tell you, and how much did you need labels to actually interpret it?

WHY THIS WORKS

A fast, visual primer for K65's core skill (data trend interpretation) and K84's critical-thinking theme, showing that a pattern alone isn't the same as genuine understanding.

SUB-SESSION 2A

One Sentence, Big Difference

TIME: 8 min

1. Show two versions of the same sentence: one dense and jargon-heavy, one clear and direct, describing the same simple idea.
2. Quick vote: which one would you actually want to read in a report?
3. Ask: what specifically made the difference?

WHY THIS WORKS

Sets up the entire section's throughline — clarity over density — before K4's report writing and K16's executive summary work begins.

SUB-SESSION 2B

The Documentation Test

TIME: 8 min

1. Pair up. Partner A gives Partner B a genuinely simple set of verbal instructions for a common task (making a sandwich, tying a shoe) — but Partner B must follow them exactly as stated, no assumed steps.
2. Watch the instructions fail in real time as unstated assumptions surface.
3. Quick debrief: what did you assume was “obvious” that actually needed to be said?

WHY THIS WORKS

A genuinely funny, fast way to prime K58's core lesson before it's introduced formally: what's obvious to you often isn't obvious to someone else.

SUB-SESSION 3A

The Planning Fallacy Poll

TIME: 8 min

1. Ask: “Think of the last project or task where your time estimate was way off. Was it too optimistic or too pessimistic?”
2. Quick show of hands — most groups skew heavily toward “too optimistic.”
3. Briefly name this as a well-documented bias (the planning fallacy) before moving into K5 and K7.

WHY THIS WORKS

Normalizes a genuinely common planning failure before asking participants to plan for real, lowering the stakes of admitting where past estimates went wrong.

SUB-SESSION 3B

Scope Creep Confessions

TIME: 8 min

1. Quick round: “Has a project you were part of ever quietly grown bigger than originally planned? What happened?”
2. One example each, fast.
3. Note the common thread: scope creep rarely arrives as one big decision — it's usually many small ones.

WHY THIS WORKS

Primes K27 (Process Improvement) and K37 (Mini Project Completed) by making the abstract idea of scope discipline concrete and personally relatable.

SUB-SESSION 3C

The Delegation Dilemma

TIME: 8 min

1. Pose a quick scenario: “You have a task you're genuinely better at than your teammate, but they need the practice. Do you do it yourself or delegate it?”
2. Quick group discussion, no need to resolve it definitively.
3. Flag that this exact tension is what K74 (Task Delegation) is actually about.

WHY THIS WORKS

Surfaces the genuine tension in delegation, doing it well versus doing it fast, before the formal exercise asks participants to navigate it for real.

SUB-SESSION 4A

Death by PowerPoint

TIME: 8 min

1. Show a deliberately terrible slide: dense paragraphs, tiny font, no visual hierarchy.
2. Quick reactions: what's the very first thing your eye does when this appears on screen?
3. Contrast briefly with what a clear slide would do instead.

WHY THIS WORKS

A fast, visual, slightly comic way to set up K3's core lesson: slides support a speaker, they don't replace one.

SUB-SESSION 4B

Explain It to My Grandmother

TIME: 8 min

1. Pick one genuinely technical concept familiar to the group (a spreadsheet formula, a coding concept, a statistical term).
2. Ask for a volunteer to explain it in one sentence, as if to someone with zero technical background.
3. Try a second volunteer with a different concept if time allows — notice how hard genuine simplification actually is.

WHY THIS WORKS

Directly primes K51 (Technical Presentation to Non-Experts), making the challenge of the actual exercise viscerally clear before it starts.

SUB-SESSION 5A

Tool Graveyard

TIME: 8 min

1. Quick round: “Name one tool or app you downloaded with real excitement and then never actually used.”
2. One tool each, fast, a little self-deprecating humor is fine.

3. Note the pattern: adoption requires more than initial enthusiasm.

WHY THIS WORKS

Sets up K78 (Reflection on Tool Efficiency) later in the stage, and lightly primes the honest self-assessment this whole section requires.

SUB-SESSION 5B

The Automation You Wish Existed

TIME: 8 min

1. Quick round: "What's one repetitive task in your life you wish could just happen automatically?"
2. One idea each, genuinely playful, no need for it to be realistic yet.
3. Flag that K47 (Task Automation Attempted) is about to make at least one of these ideas genuinely real.

WHY THIS WORKS

Builds real enthusiasm and personal stakes for the automation exercise before it starts, rather than presenting it as an abstract technical task.

SUB-SESSION 6A

The Best Feedback I Ever Got

TIME: 8 min

1. Quick round: "What's the single most useful piece of feedback anyone has ever given you, professionally or academically?"
2. One example each — encourage genuine specificity over a generic answer.
3. Note what made it useful: specificity, timing, delivery.

WHY THIS WORKS

Sets a genuinely reflective tone for this closing section and primes K19 (Peer Review) and K29 (Feedback Integration) with a real, positive reference point.

SUB-SESSION 6B

One Thing I'd Tell My Past Self

TIME: 10 min

1. Ask each participant to silently think of one thing they'd tell themselves at the very start of this stage, ninety FIRSTS ago.
2. Quick round-robin, one sentence each.
3. Note any common threads across the group's answers before moving into the stage's closing reflections.

WHY THIS WORKS

A genuine, low-pressure warm-up for the heavy reflective work in this final sub-session (K56, K60, K85), and a fitting way to open the close of the largest stage in the program.